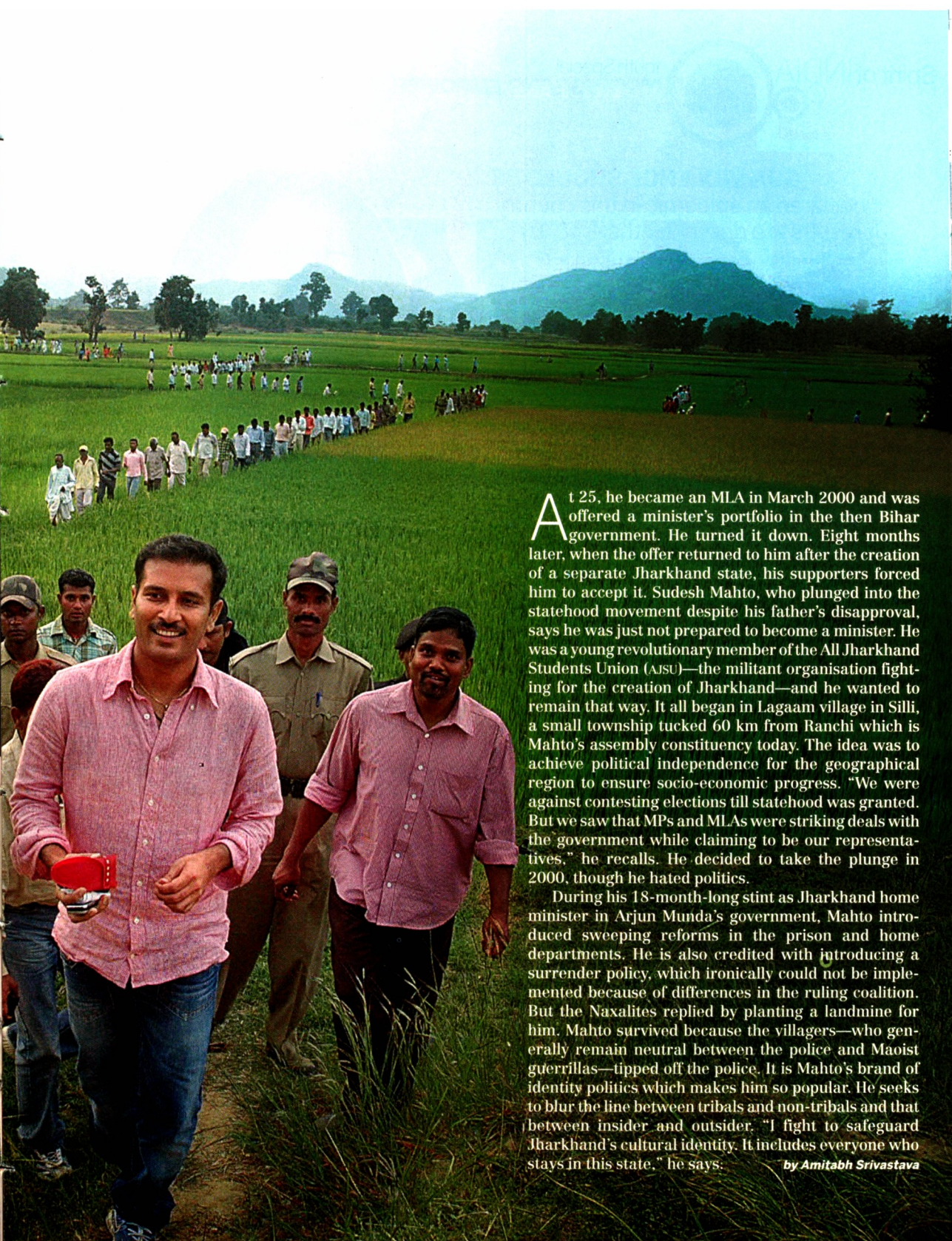




At 25, he became an MLA in March 2000 and was offered a minister's portfolio in the then Bihar government. He turned it down. Eight months later, when the offer returned to him after the creation of a separate Jharkhand state, his supporters forced him to accept it. Sudesh Mahto, who plunged into the statehood movement despite his father's disapproval, says he was just not prepared to become a minister. He was a young revolutionary member of the All Jharkhand Students Union (AJSU)—the militant organisation fighting for the creation of Jharkhand—and he wanted to remain that way. It all began in Lagaam village in Silli, a small township tucked 60 km from Ranchi which is Mahto's assembly constituency today. The idea was to achieve political independence for the geographical region to ensure socio-economic progress. "We were against contesting elections till statehood was granted. But we saw that MPs and MLAs were striking deals with the government while claiming to be our representatives," he recalls. He decided to take the plunge in 2000, though he hated politics.

During his 18-month-long stint as Jharkhand home minister in Arjun Munda's government, Mahto introduced sweeping reforms in the prison and home departments. He is also credited with introducing a surrender policy, which ironically could not be implemented because of differences in the ruling coalition. But the Naxalites replied by planting a landmine for him. Mahto survived because the villagers—who generally remain neutral between the police and Maoist guerrillas—tipped off the police. It is Mahto's brand of identity politics which makes him so popular. He seeks to blur the line between tribals and non-tribals and that between insider and outsider. "I fight to safeguard Jharkhand's cultural identity. It includes everyone who stays in this state," he says.

by Amitabh Srivastava

MRITUNJAY KUMAR OJHA